THE MISSION ARCHITECT'S FIELD GUIDE

Start with performance. Make the thinking playable.



Two-page quick reference • Keep it handy while designing your first prototype.

FIVE STEPS FROM WORKPLACE NEED TO LEARNING GAME

01	**FIND THE PERFORMANCE GAP**	Where are people struggling, and is practice an appropriate response? **OUTPUT A behavior worth practicing**
02	**MAKE SUCCESS OBSERVABLE**	Given which information, what action will learners take, and what counts as correct? **OUTPUT A measurable objective and success criteria**
03	**CHOOSE MECHANIC + STORY**	Choose an action that requires the target thinking, then add role, problem, and stakes. **OUTPUT A playable concept and meaningful story**
04	**BUILD THE CHALLENGE**	Create the evidence, rules, artifacts, and answer key; test with a fresh solver. **OUTPUT A playable, verified prototype**
05	**DESIGN FEEDBACK + TRANSFER**	Plan self-checks, hints, debrief, recovery, and a new situation to test the skill. **OUTPUT A feedback and transfer plan**

HYPOTHETICAL HQ TEACHING EXAMPLE

A fictional support crew receives FOUR incident reports and an escalation guide. Players classify the alerts by urgency and explain the evidence behind each decision. Correct classifications earn a symbol for the next challenge. This four-alert example is deliberately simpler than The Backup League game, which uses SIX dispatch reports.

DESIGN RULE Could someone win without using the target behavior? If yes, redesign the interaction.

A theme supplies purpose and stakes. The mechanic should require the same thinking learners need beyond the game.

YOUR FIRST MISSION / QUICK DESIGN CANVAS

Use these four questions to sketch a five-minute prototype or start a fuller design canvas.

TASK

What decision or skill must people practice?

SUCCESS

What would observable success look like?

MECHANIC

What must players sort, compare, sequence, route, or assemble?

FEEDBACK

How will players get help and understand why they are right?

THE FIVE-MINUTE NOVICE TEST

- ☐ Can someone start without an oral explanation from the designer?
- ☐ Can a player reach and justify the intended solution using supplied evidence?
- ☐ Can they self-check, request a hint, and recover at time-up?
- ☐ Do instructions stay readable and usable with the actual room, group, and devices?
- ☐ Can you ask a new scenario or debrief question to check learning beyond finishing?

ONE USEFUL ENDING

Debrief the decision: “Which clue mattered, what did you decide, and how would that reasoning apply elsewhere?”

Resources: https://tinyurl.com/DevLearnEscape

AI ART ATTRIBUTION Selected character artwork was generated with OpenAI image-generation tools and adapted for this resource. AI-assisted text drafting was reviewed and edited by the author.